

PHYS 357: Honours Quantum Physics 1

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Abstract

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1 Introduction

Textbook used is JS Townsend, *A Modern Approach to Quantum Mechanics*, 2nd ed., University Science Books 2012. Taught by Bill Coish. Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays from 9:35 to 10:25 in Steward Biology Building N2/2. Course grading is divided as follows:

- 10% problem sets (must be handwritten scans).
- 40% quizzes (on Wednesdays, best 8 of 12).
- 20% midterms (best of 2, October 2nd and November 6th).
- 30% final exam.

2 Stern-Gerlach Experiments

2.1 The classical picture

2.1.1 Angular momentum

Definition 1 (Orbital angular momentum). *The orbital angular momentum of a particle is*

$$\vec{L} = \vec{r} \times \vec{p}, \quad (1)$$

where $\vec{r}$ is the position vector and $\vec{p} = m\vec{v}$ is the linear momentum.

For motion confined to the x - y plane, only the z component survives. On a circular path of radius r with speed v ,

$$L_z = mvr.$$

Definition 2 (Angular momentum of a rigid body). *For a rigid body¹ rotating about a fixed axis this is*

$$L = I_0\omega, \quad (2)$$

with I_0 the moment of inertia and ω the angular velocity.

Remark 1. *The moment of inertia I_0 measures how mass is distributed relative to the rotation axis.*

2.1.2 Magnetic moment of a circulating charge

Definition 3 (Magnetic moment). *A magnetic moment is a measure of the net circulation of electric charge. It is a vector quantity that determines the torque a magnet will experience in an external magnetic field.*

¹A rigid body is one that does not deform under the action of external forces.

The magnetic moment of a point particle of mass m and charge q in a circular orbit of radius r and period T is

$$\mu = \frac{IA}{c} = \frac{1}{c} \left(\frac{qv}{2\pi r} \right) (\pi r^2) = \frac{q}{2mc} mvr = \frac{q}{2mc} L_z, \quad (3)$$

where I is the current and A is the area enclosed by the orbit. A single circulating charge counts as a steady current $I = q/T = qv/2\pi r$ because it passes any given point on the loop once per period.

2.1.3 Gyromagnetic ratio

Definition 4 (Gyromagnetic ratio). *The gyromagnetic ratio γ is the constant of proportionality between the magnetic moment and the angular momentum,*

$$\vec{\mu} = \gamma \vec{L}. \quad (4)$$

For the circulating charge above,

$$\gamma = \frac{q}{2mc}. \quad (5)$$

Remark 2. *This is a purely classical result, since the charge is treated as a point particle on a definite orbit with a definite radius and speed, and nothing is quantized. It matters here because measuring $\vec{\mu}$ is how we measure $\vec{L}$, and it is what the Stern-Gerlach apparatus exploits.*

2.2 Spin

Definition 5 (Spin). *Spin $\vec{S}$ is an intrinsic angular momentum carried by a particle. It is a fixed property of the particle type, like charge or mass, and does not come from any motion through space. A stationary electron alone in empty space still has spin.*

In quantum mechanics the spin $\vec{S}$ replaces the orbital angular momentum $\vec{L}$ of the classical picture.

2.2.1 Intrinsic moment and the g-factor

The magnetic moment is still proportional to the angular momentum, but the gyromagnetic ratio picks up an extra dimensionless factor,

$$\vec{\mu} = \gamma \vec{S}, \quad \gamma = \frac{qg}{2mc}, \quad (6)$$

where g is the g-factor of the particle.

Definition 6 (g-factor). *The g-factor of a particle³ is the dimensionless number relating its magnetic moment to its spin angular momentum. It measures how much stronger or weaker the moment is than the classical value $\gamma = q/2mc$, which corresponds to $g = 1$.*

²Here c is in Gaussian units.

³Its value must be measured or derived from relativistic quantum theory.

2.2.2 Magnetons

Definition 7 (Planck constant). *The Planck constant h is the fundamental constant of quantum mechanics. It sets the scale at which quantization matters, and relates the energy of a photon to its frequency by $E = h\nu$. Its value is*

$$h \approx 6.626 \times 10^{-34} \text{ J s.} \quad (7)$$

It has units of $J \cdot s$, which is the same as angular momentum.

Definition 8 (Reduced Planck constant).

$$\hbar = \frac{h}{2\pi}. \quad (8)$$

It carries units of angular momentum, so $[\hbar] = [L_z] = \frac{\text{kg} \cdot \text{m}^2}{\text{s}}$.

Writing $\vec{S} = \hbar(\vec{S}/\hbar)$ with $\vec{S}/\hbar$ dimensionless, the $\hbar$ joins the gyromagnetic ratio. The combination $q\hbar/2mc$ then carries the units and sets the natural size of the moment at a given mass scale.

Definition 9 (Bohr magneton). *The Bohr magneton is the natural unit of magnetic moment for an electron,*

$$\mu_B = \frac{|e|\hbar}{2m_e c}. \quad (9)$$

Definition 10 (Nuclear magneton). *The nuclear magneton is the same combination with the proton mass, and is the natural unit for nucleons,*

$$\mu_N = \frac{|e|\hbar}{2m_p c}. \quad (10)$$

Since $m_p/m_e \approx 1836$, we have $\mu_N \approx \mu_B/1836$.

Definition 11 (Nucleons). *The subatomic particles that make up the nucleus of an atom, specifically protons and neutrons.*

The electron moment is then written as

$$\vec{\mu}_e = g_e \mu_B \frac{\vec{S}}{\hbar}, \quad (11)$$

and similarly for the proton and neutron with μ_N in place of μ_B .

2.2.3 Values for the electron, proton and neutron

Particle	Charge q	Mass m	g -factor	Gyromagnetic ratio γ
Electron	$- e $	m_e	$g_e \approx 2$	$g_e \mu_B / \hbar$
Proton	$+ e $	m_p	$g_p \approx 5.59$	$g_p \mu_N / \hbar$
Neutron	0	m_p	$g_n \approx -3.83$	$g_n \mu_N / \hbar$

Table 1: Charges, masses, g -factors and gyromagnetic ratios.

Remark 3. The classical derivation gives $\mu = (q/2mc)L_z$, which vanishes when $q = 0$. The neutron is neutral yet has a nonzero moment, so its $\vec{\mu}$ cannot come from a single circulating point charge. This is a first sign that the classical picture fails.

Remark 4. Since $m_p \gg m_e$, we get $\mu_N \ll \mu_B$ and therefore $|\vec{\mu}_p| \ll |\vec{\mu}_e|$. Stern-Gerlach deflection of nuclei is much weaker than for electrons.

2.3 The Stern-Gerlach apparatus

Definition 12 (Stern-Gerlach apparatus). A device that measures one component of a particle's magnetic moment. A beam of neutral atoms passes through a magnet shaped to produce a strong field gradient along a chosen axis, here z . The gradient deflects each atom by an amount proportional to μ_z , and a screen records where it lands. Since $\vec{\mu} = \gamma\vec{S}$, the position on the screen is a direct measurement of S_z .

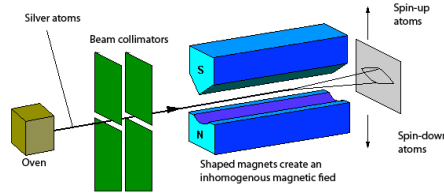


Figure 1: Illustration of the Stern-Gerlach apparatus.

2.3.1 Force in an inhomogeneous field

A magnetic moment in a field has potential energy

$$U = -\vec{\mu} \cdot \vec{B}, \quad (12)$$

so the force on it is

$$\vec{F} = -\vec{\nabla}U = \vec{\nabla}(\vec{\mu} \cdot \vec{B}), \quad F_z = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial z} = \mu_z \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z}. \quad (13)$$

Definition 13 (Deflection). The transverse displacement of an atom on the screen, produced by the force F_z acting over the length of the magnet. It is proportional to μ_z , so the pattern on the screen is a record of the moments in the beam.

Remark 5. A uniform field gives no force, only a torque. The apparatus needs a field gradient to deflect anything.

2.3.2 Silver atoms

Silver is used because its net orbital angular momentum vanishes, $\vec{L} = 0$, while $\vec{S} \neq 0$. The entire magnetic moment comes from a single unpaired valence electron, so the atom behaves as one electron spin. For the electron,

$$\mu_z = -\frac{g_e |e|}{2m_e c} S_z, \quad (14)$$

and therefore

$$F_z = \mu_z \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z} = -g_e \frac{|e|}{2m_e c} S_z \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z} = g_e \frac{|e|}{2m_e c} \left| \frac{\partial B_z}{\partial z} \right| S_z, \quad (15)$$

where the last equality assumes $\partial B_z / \partial z < 0$.

Result 1.

$$F_z \propto S_z. \quad (16)$$

The deflection of an atom measures the z component of its spin directly.

2.3.3 The classical prediction

Spin is a vector,

$$\vec{S} = (S_x, S_y, S_z)^T, \quad S_z = |\vec{S}| \cos \theta. \quad (17)$$

Remark 6. *The spins leaving the oven point in random directions, so θ takes every value in $[0, \pi]$ across the beam and $S_z = |\vec{S}| \cos \theta$ takes every value in $[-|\vec{S}|, |\vec{S}|]$. Since $F_z \propto S_z$, each atom is deflected differently and the screen should show a continuous smear. It shows two spots.*

2.4 Quantization of S_z

Result 2 (Quantization of spin). *The electron spin angular momentum is quantized:*

$$S_z = \pm \frac{\hbar}{2}. \quad (18)$$

The beam splits into two spots.

2.4.1 Ket notation

Definition 14 (Ket notation). *A ket $|\cdot\rangle$ labels a quantum state as a vector in a vector space. For electron spin the two measurement outcomes give the basis states*

$$|\uparrow\rangle \text{ for } S_z = +\frac{\hbar}{2}, \quad |\downarrow\rangle \text{ for } S_z = -\frac{\hbar}{2}.$$

The space is two-dimensional, so any spin state is a linear combination of the two.

A Appendix

B Useful Links

Stern-Gerlach experiment: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/QG7kJXxN1Kk>